

INFORMATION SHEET FOR PARTICIPANTS

Ethical Clearance Reference Number: **[INSERT ONCE PROVIDED BY REVIEW BODY]**



YOU WILL BE GIVEN A COPY OF THIS INFORMATION SHEET

The Cycle Study: Exploring symptoms of PMDD across the menstrual cycle

I would like to invite you to participate in this research project undertaken by staff at the IoPPN, KCL. Before you decide whether you want to take part, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what your participation will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Ask me if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information.

What is the purpose of the project?

The purpose of the project is to better understand what Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder (PMDD) is like for people across the menstrual cycle by collecting data on the type of symptoms experienced, severity of symptoms, and possible influencing factors. We aim to better understand how experiences of PMDD change across the menstrual cycle, and how PMDD is affected by wider health experiences and the social environment.

Why have I been invited to take part?

To take part in the Cycle Study you must own a wearable device and have a diagnosis of PMDD

And:

- Be aged 18-45
- Live in the UK
- Be fluent in English

It is possible that you may not be able to participate in our study. This may happen if you meet any of the following exclusion criteria:

- You are currently pregnant or breastfeeding
- You are currently using hormonal contraception
- You are currently experiencing a mental health crisis and are under the support of an NHS crisis team for your mental health or have been in the last 6 months
- You do not own a smartphone
- You do not own a wearable device (E.g., Fitbit, Garmin, Apple Watch, Aura Ring)

Additionally, we may already have enough people to take part in the study.

If you are not able to participate, we will inform you via email. If you do take part and at any point during the study you indicate you have started to receive support from a crisis team, you will need to stop taking part.

What will happen if I take part?

If you choose to take part in the study, you will be asked to provide your name and email. This will be used to support recruitment into the study. You will first be sent a screening questionnaire for the study to see if you are eligible to take part.

If you meet the inclusion criteria for the study, you will be invited to complete an initial questionnaire about PMDD, how long you have experienced PMDD, mental health symptoms, and to gather demographic information. Then, we will ask you to download an app onto your smartphone. We will share information on how to use the smartphone app with you via an email including a comprehensive guide. The apps will send notifications to your phone, asking you to answer some questions:

1. We will ask you to complete a short questionnaire each day for two menstrual cycles. This will include questions about your symptoms of PMDD and severity. Each daily questionnaire will take between **3-5 minutes** to complete.
2. Every week you will be invited to complete a longer questionnaire of around **10 minutes** with open-ended questions about what might have made your symptoms worse, or better, each week, and any other health experiences. This questionnaire will include mental health measures every fortnight. For the weekly questionnaire, you may choose to answer the open-text questions via typing text or recording a voice note. Any identifiable information will be removed from the data before analysis.

We will not have access to any other information, such as the content of your calls or messages or what websites you are visiting. During the study period, we will ask you to carry on with your daily routine as usual. We will give you the contact information for the research team, in case you have any problems.

We will also collect information from your wearable device such as your step count, heart rate, temperature, and sleep data. This will include all previously recorded data and will continue to record this data for the duration of the study. We will ask you to wear your device constantly for **two menstrual cycles** (or 8-10 weeks). The only times we will ask you to take it off is to charge it, or when you are taking a shower, bath or swimming. You might also need to take it off occasionally for a specific personal reason. All of the information collected in this way will be de-identified.

If we stop receiving information from the apps or the wearable device, we will be in touch with you to check that they are still working and to find out if you are having any problems.

Do I have to take part?

Participation is completely voluntary. You should only take part if you want to and choosing not to take part will not disadvantage you in any way. Once you have read the information sheet, please contact us if you have any questions that will help you make a decision about taking part. If you decide to take part, we will ask you to sign a consent form.

Incentives

You will receive a £30 voucher at the end of the data collection as a token of thanks for taking part. If you need to withdraw partway through due to receiving care from a crisis team, you will still receive the voucher.

What are the possible risks of taking part?

You may find tracking and recording your symptoms of PMDD or mental health difficult, due to the sensitive nature of the research. In this study, we ask about your mental health symptoms and experiences, which might include suicidal ideation or intent to self-harm. We offer suggestions for support at the end of this document, and after each questionnaire. You can contact us at any time using the email [\[study_email_address\]@kcl.ac.uk](mailto:[study_email_address]@kcl.ac.uk) and we can provide additional suggestions for support. However, please note that this email address will only be monitored during working hours (Monday-Friday 9-5pm).

For crisis support you can contact the following organisations:

1. NHS 111 or NHS 999 – more information is available here: [Where to get urgent help for mental health - NHS](#)
2. Samaritans: calling 116 123 or emailing jo@samaritans.org for a reply within 24 hours; <https://www.samaritans.org/how-we-can-help/contact-samaritan/>
3. Texting "SHOUT" at 85258 to contact the Shout Crisis Text Line; [Shout: the UK's free, confidential and 24/7 mental health text service for crisis support | Shout 85258](#)

The research team will not hold a clinical responsibility for those taking part, and we recommend you reaching out to your GP or a mental health professional for support.

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

There are no direct benefits to the participants from taking part. Our aim is that this study informs a larger future study that would contribute to a better understanding of PMDD to help inform effective support.

Data handling and confidentiality

Kings College London is the Sponsor of this research and is responsible for looking after your information.

We will need to use information from you for this research project. The research team and authorised administrative staff will use this information to do the research or to check your records to make sure that the research is being done properly.

Your data will be processed in compliance with UK data protection laws, including the UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018.

Categories of Personal Data	We will collect your name, date of birth, contact details, health data, biographical information such as gender and marital status, ethnicity, sexual orientation, and device identifier to use data from a wearable device such as a Garmin. If you choose to answer questions orally, we will record your voice instead of typing answers. ,
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Data Storage	Data will be stored electronically on King's network, with appropriate access controls.
Data Sharing	Data will only be shared amongst the immediate research team at King's College London. The only exception to this is that your information may also be subject to review by responsible individuals from the College for monitoring and audit purposes. Quotes from the data will be shared in external outputs in ways that are anonymised and non-identifiable.
International Data Sharing	Data will not be shared outside the UK.
Data Retention	Data can be retained for up to 10 years, in line with the King's College London's data retention policy. All data will be anonymised by completion of the project. If you consent to receiving a copy of the findings at the end of your study, your email address will be stored for this purpose and deleted after the report has been sent to you.
Anonymity in Research Outputs	Participants will remain anonymous in research outputs.
Archiving/Future Use	Anonymised data may be used by the research team in future research.

Further information on how King's processes research data can be found at:
<https://www.kcl.ac.uk/research/support/research-ethics/kings-college-london-statement-on-use-of-personal-data-in-research>

Please contact the research team if you require further information on data processing or a printed version of the webpage link above.

What if I change my mind about taking part?

You are free to withdraw at any point of the project, without having to give a reason. Withdrawing from the project will not affect you in any way. You are able to withdraw your data from the project up until four weeks after taking part, after which withdrawal of your data will no longer be possible. If you choose to withdraw from the project we will not retain the information you have given thus far.

How is the project being funded?

This project is being jointly funded by a King's Population Health Institute Investigator Award and a King's Institute of Psychiatry, Psychology, and Neuroscience Vice Dean Research Seed Fund.

What will happen to the results of the project?

The results of the project will be published in academic journals, presented at conferences, summarised in accessible outputs such as blogposts, and in student BSc or MSc dissertations.

Who should I contact for further information?

If you have any questions or require more information about this project, please contact me using the following contact details:

Dr Catherine Jones
catherine.2.jones@kcl.ac.uk
Office phone number: 0207-848-0470
Social, Genetic and Developmental Psychiatry Centre
King's College London
Memory Lane
London
SE5 8AF

What if I have further questions, or if something goes wrong?

If this project has harmed you in any way or if you wish to make a complaint about the conduct of the project you can contact King's College London using the details below for further advice and information:

The Chair, Health Committees Ethics Board, rec@kcl.ac.uk

Suggested support resources:

The following websites are recommended for support for mental health and relationships:

- <https://www.mind.org.uk/need-urgent-help/using-this-tool/>
- <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/premenstrual-dysphoric-disorder-pmdd/>
- https://www.samaritans.org/how-we-can-help/?gad_source=1&gclid=Cj0KCQiA_NC9BhCkARIsABSnSTbBDebOPy_kIPmhAtWs2Lt6c72TzFYk7FyDYAZSy0Y4FY05QRloNkaAoEeEALw_wcB
- <https://www.relate.org.uk/>

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering taking part in this research.